

Haligric Research Integration Series

CADDO CONFEDERACY

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Texas, Louisiana, Oklahoma — The Original People of Texas, Mound Builders, and the Tradition That Named the Lone Star State

The word Texas comes from the Caddo word tayshas —
meaning 'friends' or 'allies.'

The state of Texas is named for what the Caddo called the people they welcomed.

The Caddo have been in East Texas for at least a thousand years.

Their mounds still rise from the East Texas pinewoods.

Their pottery is still being made.

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A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Caddo Sovereignty

The Caddo Nation of Oklahoma is the contemporary nation descended from the historic Caddo Confederacy. The Caddo people maintain specific control over their sacred knowledge, and many aspects of their ceremonial tradition are held as community knowledge not appropriate for public dissemination. This document presents what Caddo cultural representatives, tribal historians, and archaeologists working in collaboration with the Caddo Nation have shared in public contexts. The most restricted ceremonial content — specific prayers, specific sacred songs, the most protected aspects of the healing tradition — belong to the community and are not reproduced here.

Introduction — The Original People of Texas

The Caddo (the name comes from a shortening of 'Kadohadacho,' one of the major Caddo groups) are the Indigenous people who have inhabited the Piney Woods of East Texas, western Louisiana, southwestern Arkansas, and southeastern Oklahoma for at least a thousand years — and based on archaeological evidence, for significantly longer. They are the original people of the landscape that is now Texas, and the state's very name is the most lasting record of their presence.

The word 'Texas' comes from the Caddo word 'tayshas' — meaning 'friends' or 'allies.' When Spanish explorers arrived in Caddo territory in the late 17th century and asked the people they met who they were, the Caddo extended their traditional greeting of welcome and alliance. The Spanish recorded the word as 'Tejas,' and it became the name of the region, the republic, and ultimately the state. The largest state in the contiguous United States carries a Caddo word as its name — the record of a welcome extended to strangers who would eventually remove the people who gave it.

Who the Caddo Are — Identity, Language, and the Caddoan World

The Caddo are a Southeastern people — linguistically and culturally related to the broader Southeastern Indigenous world (Creek, Cherokee, Choctaw, Chickasaw, Caddo healing tradition parallels the wider Southeastern healing framework) while maintaining their own distinct identity, language, and sacred tradition. The Caddoan language family includes Caddo proper (Hasinai), Pawnee, Arikara, and Wichita — languages that extend from Texas north into the Great Plains, evidence of a broader Caddoan cultural sphere that once stretched across a large portion of the continent.

The Caddo refer to themselves as 'Hasínay' — the people. Their territory at the height of their civilization (roughly 800-1400 CE, the peak of the Caddo mound-building period) extended across a large swath of the Southeastern-Plains transition zone — a region of pine forests, river bottoms, and grassland margins that provided both the agricultural base and the trade connections that sustained Caddo civilization.

The Caddo Confederacy — Three Major Groups

KADOHADACHO

The northernmost major group — located primarily along the Red River in what is now southwestern Arkansas and northeastern Texas. The name Caddo derives from a shortening of Kadohadacho. This group had the most extensive trading relationships with other nations to the north and east.

HASINAI

The largest major group — located in the deep East Texas Piney Woods, in the territory around what is now Nacogdoches, Rusk, and Cherokee counties. The Hasinai were the Caddo most extensively encountered by Spanish and French colonizers, and it was from encounters with Hasinai communities that the word tayshas entered the colonial record.

NATCHITOCHES

The southernmost major group — located along the Red River in what is now northwestern Louisiana, in the territory around present-day Natchitoches, Louisiana (which preserves their name). The Natchitoches were the primary Caddo trading partners for French Louisiana, and their alliance with France shaped the colonial-era Caddo diplomatic strategy.

Caddo Origins — The Emergence Narrative

Caddo cosmology presents a specific origin story — the emergence narrative — in which the first people lived underground before coming into this world. In the emergence narrative, the first people came up through a cave or underground passage, guided by specific sacred beings, carrying specific sacred knowledge and specific sacred objects (the sacred fire, specific ceremonies) with them into the world above.

The specific details of the emergence narrative are held by the Caddo Nation and transmitted through their oral tradition. What the public record documents is the basic structure: the people came from below, guided upward by sacred beings, bringing with them the knowledge and ceremonies that define Caddo sacred life. The foundational structure is documented: the people came from below through a cave called Chákanína — the place of crying — near the Red River. A venerated elder led the emergence carrying fire, a pipe, and a drum; his wife carried corn and pumpkin seeds. Before all the people reached the surface the hole was closed; those who emerged wept for those left behind. Because the Caddo came out of the earth and return to it when they die, they call the earth iná — Mother.

Caddo Cosmology — The Sacred World

Caddo cosmology presents a layered sacred universe — a world above, a world below, and the world of human beings in between — organized around the relationship between the supreme being (Ayo Caddi Aymay), the sky chief (Caddi Ayo), the sacred fire, and the community of human beings who maintain the sacred relationships through ceremony.

THE SACRED FIRE: The sacred fire is the primary medium of communication between the human and spirit worlds — the living presence of the divine in the community, the center around which ceremony moves, and the specific continuity that connects the contemporary Caddo Nation to their ancestral homeland. Like the Alabama-Coushatta (their neighbors and cultural relatives), the Caddo maintain a sacred fire tradition whose centrality to ceremonial life reflects the shared Southeastern Indigenous understanding of fire as the Creator's presence.

THE SACRED DIRECTIONS: The four cardinal directions carry specific sacred associations in the Caddo world — each direction associated with specific sacred beings, specific sacred qualities, and specific ceremonial orientations. The east is particularly significant — the direction of dawn, of the Morning Star, and of the Creator's light entering the world. Caddo ceremonial structures are oriented to the cardinal directions, encoding the cosmological framework in the physical space of ceremony. The Pleiades — called the Star Women — held specific sacred significance in the Caddo ceremonial calendar, observed during the fall harvest ceremony held with the September new moon.

Ayo Caddi Aymay — The Supreme Being

Ayo Caddi Aymay (sometimes rendered as 'Ayo Caddi Aymay' or in various orthographies — the Caddo language's specific sounds do not map cleanly onto English spelling) is the supreme being of the Caddo tradition — 'the one who is most powerful,' the creator of the world and the ultimate sacred source. Ayo Caddi Aymay is present throughout creation but approached primarily through specific intermediaries — particularly the Caddi Ayo (sky chief) who serves as the primary divine intermediary, and through the sacred fire that carries prayers from the human world to the divine world.

The Caddo understanding of the supreme being reflects the broader Southeastern Indigenous pattern: the ultimate sacred source is present everywhere but does not intervene directly in human affairs; instead, the community maintains its relationship with the sacred through specific ceremonies, specific offerings, and specific sacred practitioners who know the specific protocols of approach.

The Spirit World — Caddi Ayo and the Sacred Beings

CADDI AYO: The 'chief of the sky' — a powerful divine being who serves as the primary intermediary between Ayo Caddi Aymay and the human community. The Caddi Ayo governs specific aspects of the sacred world and is addressed in specific ceremonies, particularly those oriented toward the sky and the astronomical phenomena that mark the sacred calendar.

ANCESTOR SPIRITS: The Caddo sacred world includes a populated invisible dimension — ancestor spirits who remain active participants in community life. The honored dead — particularly the Xinesi and other sacred leaders — continue to protect and guide the living from their position in the sacred landscape. Burial in the mound placed the

honored dead at the community's sacred center, the most powerful possible location for an ancestor to continue their protective work.

NATURE SPIRITS: Nature spirits associated with specific sacred animals and plants are part of the Caddo sacred world. The deer, the eagle, and specific other animals carry sacred authority; specific plants — particularly the yaupon holly, the tobacco, and the cedar — are understood as sacred beings with their own authority and their own specific ceremonial roles.

The Xinesi — The Sacred Priest-Chief

The Xinesi (also rendered as Xinesi or Chenesi — the sacred priest-chief of the Caddo) was the most important single office in the Caddo sacred and political world — the person who held the specific sacred knowledge of the tradition, who conducted the most important ceremonies, who maintained the most direct relationship with the sacred beings, and who represented the community before the divine world.

THE XINESI'S ROLE: The Xinesi was simultaneously a sacred specialist (knowing the specific ceremonies, the specific prayers, the specific sacred knowledge of the tradition) and a political leader (whose sacred authority gave them specific political standing in the community). The two roles were inseparable — the Xinesi's political authority derived from their sacred standing, and their sacred standing required constant renewal through ceremonial practice.

THE XINESI AT DEATH: When a Xinesi died, the transition was a sacred crisis for the entire community. The Xinesi was buried within the temple itself or in a dedicated burial mound, accompanied by lavish grave goods reflecting the office's singular status — burial practice setting the Xinesi visibly apart from the ordinary community even in death, in recognition of a role no other Caddo office was permitted to hold. The selection and training of the next Xinesi was a community process of the highest sacred importance.

The Caddo Mounds — Sacred Architecture and Cosmological Space

The Caddo earthen mounds — platform mounds on which temples and the Xinesi's residence were constructed, burial mounds that held the honored dead in the sacred center of community life, and processional mounds that organized the ceremonial landscape — are the most physically impressive surviving expression of Caddo civilization and among the most significant sacred sites in Texas.

WHAT THE MOUNDS ARE

Caddo mounds are deliberately constructed earthen elevations — built by the community through sustained collective labor over generations. The largest mounds at the Caddo Mounds State Historic Site (near Alto, Texas) are approximately 20 feet high and were built incrementally over centuries — each layer of earth representing a specific ceremonial action, a specific period of community effort, a specific sacred intention.

THE TEMPLE MOUNDS

The largest mounds supported temples and the Xinesi's residence — placing the most sacred buildings and the most sacred person at the highest point in the community's landscape. The elevation was cosmological, not merely practical: the temple closer to the sky was closer to the divine beings who governed from above.

THE BURIAL MOUNDS

Honored community members — particularly the Xinesi and other sacred leaders — were buried within mounds, with specific grave goods and specific ceremonies marking the transition. Burial in the mound placed the honored dead at the community's sacred center — the most powerful possible location for an ancestor to continue their protective work.

Mound Construction as Sacred Ceremony

The building of a mound was not a construction project that happened to have religious significance. It was a ceremony. The specific earth used, the specific order of deposit, the specific timing of construction phases — all were governed by sacred knowledge held by the Xinesi and transmitted through the tradition. Each basket of earth carried to the mound was a sacred act.

Archaeological evidence shows that mound construction often involved the intentional layering of specific materials — burned structures, specific soils, specific objects — in sequences that reflect ceremonial rather than purely practical logic. The mound was built the way it was built because the sacred tradition specified that it be built that way, not because engineers optimized for efficiency.

The Caddo Mounds State Historic Site — Reopened May 2024

The Caddo Mounds State Historic Site is managed by the Texas Historical Commission in consultation with the Caddo Nation of Oklahoma. The contemporary Caddo community maintains a living relationship with these sites — the mounds are not merely archaeological features but sacred sites that belong to a living people.

On Caddo Culture Day, May 2019, an EF-3 tornado struck the Caddo Mounds State Historic Site, killing one visitor and causing catastrophic damage to the visitor center, facilities, and interpretive structures. The site closed immediately. The Texas Legislature allocated \$2.5 million for restoration, and the site underwent a multi-year rebuilding process with significant input from the Caddo Nation of Oklahoma on how to represent the tradition accurately and respectfully.

On May 18, 2024, the Caddo Mounds State Historic Site reopened to the public with a fully rebuilt visitor center and updated interpretive materials developed in collaboration with the Caddo Nation. The reopening was a significant moment for both the site and for the Caddo community — the return of public access to one of the most important Caddo sacred sites in Texas, with facilities that reflect the Caddo perspective on their own history and tradition.

Caddo Sacred Pottery — The Art That Speaks the Sacred

Caddo pottery is recognized by archaeologists and art historians as among the finest ceramic art produced by any culture in North America — technically sophisticated, artistically extraordinary, and saturated with cosmological content encoded in specific designs, specific shapes, and specific decorative elements.

THE TECHNICAL ACHIEVEMENT

Caddo potters developed techniques for producing vessels with walls of extraordinary thinness — some as thin as 3-4 millimeters — that maintained structural integrity and that were then decorated with engraved and incised designs of remarkable complexity and precision. The technical skill required to produce these vessels was the product of generations of knowledge transmission, making the pottery tradition simultaneously a sacred art and a sacred craft.

THE SACRED DESIGNS

The designs engraved on Caddo pottery are not decorative in the Western sense — they encode specific sacred content. Specific symbols (spirals, serpentine forms, cross-in-circle motifs, specific bird and animal representations) carry specific cosmological meanings. The pottery is sacred writing in ceramic form.

THE POTTERY TRADITION TODAY

The Caddo Nation of Oklahoma is actively working to revive the pottery tradition — teaching the specific techniques and the specific design vocabulary to community members, maintaining the ceramic knowledge as living cultural heritage rather than historical artifact. Contemporary Caddo potters are producing work that continues the tradition in living form. In July 2024, the Texas Historical Foundation sponsored a four-part workshop on traditional Caddo pottery at the Caddo Mounds State Historic Site, led by contemporary potter Chase Kahwinhut Earles, with 20 predominantly Caddo students from across the country. The workshop was filmed to provide wider educational access — an example of how the pottery revival actively bridges the historic mounds site with living Caddo cultural transmission.

Pottery as Sacred Practice — Form, Symbol, and Ceremony

Caddo pottery was produced in specific forms for specific purposes — ceremonial bottles with narrow necks that could hold liquids for ceremony, serving vessels for sacred meals, burial goods that accompanied the honored dead into the mound, and specific forms associated with specific ceremonies. The form of a vessel communicates its sacred function.

The spiral — one of the most common Caddo design elements — encodes the cosmological understanding of time and change as cyclical rather than linear. The serpentine forms reflect the sacred status of specific snakes in the Southeastern Indigenous world (the rattlesnake is particularly sacred). The cross-in-circle motif encodes the four directions and the sacred center — the fundamental Caddo cosmological structure — in visual form.

The Turkey Dance — Caddo Ceremonial Dance

The Turkey Dance (Caddo: Núh Kaʔáwshan — 'going to dance like turkeys') is one of the most important and most distinctive surviving traditional ceremonies of the Caddo people — a women's dance with 52 surviving songs, performed in the afternoon and concluded by sunset, documented back to 1687 and still held today at the Caddo National Tribal Complex in Binger, Oklahoma.

The dance's origin story tells of a Caddo man who heard singing in the forest and discovered a rafter of turkey hens dancing in a circle around a tom turkey. He memorized the dance and brought it back to his tribe. This origin is echoed in the dance's structure: women dance in a circle mimicking the turkey's gait and mannerisms, while men drum and sing.

Historically the Turkey Dance opened homecoming celebrations for returning warriors and hunters. Today it opens every day of Caddo ceremonial dancing. Its 52 surviving songs recount Caddo historical events across the many dialects of the language — beginning with the oral history of the Caddo people's creation and including historical events up to Caddo veterans of Iraq and Afghanistan. Contemporary Caddo women still dance with a ceremonial cane presented to the tribe by the Spanish before 1809. As the late Caddo tribal historian Cecile Elkins Carter wrote: 'The dances celebrate Caddo survival.' The Turkey Dance is performed by the Hasinay Society and the Caddo Cultural Club. THE DRUM DANCE: In the Drum Dance (Cah-kit-em-bin), male leaders carry the drum around the dance ground clockwise — in harmony with the earth — followed by the women. The procession begins in the west and stops at each cardinal direction. The more than 50 Drum Dance songs take the community through Caddo origins and history; it is always the first dance performed in the night's cycle at tribal functions.

The Black Drink Ceremony — Step-by-Step

The Black Drink ceremony — common across the Southeast Indigenous world but practiced by the Caddo with specific forms — was one of the most important ceremonial practices for purification, council preparation, and sacred communication. The Black Drink is made from roasted leaves of the yaupon holly (*Ilex vomitoria*), producing a highly caffeinated tea that in sufficient quantity induces purging — the physical expression of the internal purification the ceremony accomplishes.

OCCASION: The Black Drink ceremony was conducted before councils, before major ceremonies, before warfare, and at specific times in the ceremonial calendar as a collective purification practice.

PREPARATION: The yaupon holly leaves are gathered, roasted over specific fire, and brewed into a strong tea. The preparation is conducted with specific prayers acknowledging the plant's sacred character and purpose.

STEP 1 — THE GATHERING: The participants (in most documented versions, the Black Drink ceremony involved the male council and warrior society) gather in the council house or ceremonial space.

STEP 2 — THE SACRED FIRE: The sacred fire is attended and specific prayers are offered to the Creator through the fire.

STEP 3 — THE SERVING: The Black Drink is served in specific ceremonial vessels — large conch shell cups or specific Caddo ceramic vessels — and passed in a specific order that reflects the social hierarchy of those assembled.

STEP 4 — THE CEREMONIAL CALLS: Before and during drinking, specific ceremonial cries or calls are made — acknowledging the drink's sacred character and the purpose of the ceremony.

STEP 5 — THE PURGING: The purging that follows consumption is understood as the physical expression of internal purification — the body releasing what should not be carried into sacred council or sacred ceremony.

STEP 6 — THE RENEWED STATE: After the purging, the participants are understood as purified — their bodies and spirits cleansed and prepared for the sacred work ahead.

The First Fruits Ceremony — Step-by-Step

The First Fruits Ceremony — marking the harvest of the first corn of the season — was one of the most important ceremonies of the Caddo annual cycle, equivalent in function to the Green Corn Ceremony of the Alabama-Coushatta and other Southeastern peoples. The ceremony expressed gratitude for the year's sustenance, renewed the sacred relationship with the plant world, and formally opened the new harvest for community use.

PREPARATION: The Xinesi and ceremonial specialists prepare through fasting and purification. The new corn — which has been forbidden for consumption until the ceremony — is assembled.

STEP 1 — THE SACRED FIRE: The ceremony begins with specific attention to the sacred fire — prayers of gratitude to the Creator offered through the fire.

STEP 2 — THE XINESI'S PRAYERS: The Xinesi addresses the sacred beings with specific prayers of gratitude for the year's harvest, acknowledging the gift of sustenance and the sacred relationship with the agricultural world that sustains the community.

STEP 3 — THE FORMAL PRESENTATION: The first corn is formally presented to the fire — the sacred being whose presence mediates the relationship between the human community and the divine world.

STEP 4 — THE COMMUNITY EATING: The formal permission to eat the new corn is extended to the community. The communal meal is the ceremony's expression of gratitude and celebration.

STEP 5 — THE CLOSING: The ceremony closes with specific prayers of thanksgiving, and the ordinary life of the harvest season begins.

The Morning Star Ceremony — Step-by-Step

The Caddo Morning Star ceremony reflects the Caddoan peoples' deep engagement with Venus as a sacred astronomical presence and the specific sacred significance of the pre-dawn sky in their ceremonial tradition.

TIMING: The ceremony is timed to specific astronomical appearances of the Morning Star — Venus at its most prominent pre-dawn position in the eastern sky, typically in spring.

PREPARATION: The Xinesi and the ceremonial specialists prepare through fasting and specific purification. The sacred objects associated with the ceremony are assembled.

STEP 1 — THE NIGHT VIGIL: The ceremony begins in the night preceding the Morning Star's appearance — prayers, songs, and specific sacred practices conducted in the darkness in anticipation of the dawn.

STEP 2 — THE SACRED FIRE: The sacred fire burns through the night, carried and maintained with specific protocols — the community's visible link to the divine during the dark hours.

STEP 3 — THE XINESI'S PRAYERS: The Xinesi addresses the sacred beings of the sky with specific prayers acknowledging the ceremony's purpose and the community's gratitude.

STEP 4 — THE MORNING STAR APPEARS: When Venus rises in the eastern sky, the ceremony reaches its sacred climax — the assembled community faces east, specific prayers and songs are offered, and the divine being's visible appearance is formally acknowledged.

STEP 5 — THE DAWN PRAYERS: As the sun follows the Morning Star into the sky, specific prayers of gratitude and petition are offered — the ceremony bridging the night's sacred work with the day's ordinary life.

STEP 6 — THE FEAST: The ceremony closes with communal eating — food prepared specifically for the ceremony and shared as an expression of the community's gratitude.

Caddo Healing Traditions

Caddo healing tradition operates within the broader Southeastern Indigenous healing framework — understanding illness as having both physical and sacred dimensions, with treatment addressing both. The Caddo distinction between 'good medicine' (healing that works with the sacred world's order) and 'bad medicine' (healing that works against it or that has been turned toward harm) is the fundamental organizing principle of the healing tradition.

SACRED PLANT KNOWLEDGE: Caddo healers maintained extensive knowledge of the medicinal properties of plants in the East Texas Piney Woods — the specific plants for specific conditions, the specific preparation methods, and the specific ceremonial protocols that activated the plant's healing power. This knowledge was transmitted through specific lineages of healers, not available to the general community.

This healing tradition has persisted with real continuity among Caddo people and their close Southeastern relatives. **DEATH AND THE SOUL:** Among the Caddo, the soul of the deceased did not leave the vicinity of the body for six days — during this time, the living left food and water at the grave to sustain the weak soul. Before removing the body, those present passed their hands over the body from feet to head and then over their own bodies — a way of sending messages through the deceased to dead relatives. Ordinary Caddo were buried sitting, facing west, with personal equipment. More important individuals received elaborate ceremonies and coffins; the most important — particularly the Xinesi — were buried in the mounds at the community's sacred center. Muscogee Creek, Yuchi, Cherokee, Seminole, Chickasaw, and Choctaw communities all maintain contemporary practitioners who prepare what is still described as 'good medicine' and treat 'bad medicine' — evidence that the specific Caddo healing framework reflects a genuinely wider and still-living Southeastern practice.

The Caddo Language — Hasinai and the Caddoan Family

The Caddo language (Hasinai, or simply Caddo) belongs to the Caddoan language family — a family that also includes Pawnee, Arikara, Kitsai, and Wichita. The Caddoan family is linguistically isolated — it has no demonstrated relationship to the surrounding Algonquian, Siouan, or Muskogean language families, making it one of the distinct linguistic lineages of North America.

The Caddo language is highly endangered. As of July 2025, the last native speaker of Caddo, Edmond Johnson — who had worked extensively with linguists and language preservationists over the final decades of his life to document the language — passed away at the age of 95. His death marked the extinction of Caddo as a living spoken language.

Edmond Johnson died on July 14, 2025, at age 95 — the last fluent speaker of the Caddo language. His death is a watershed moment. At the same time, the Caddo Nation and language preservationist Alaina Tahlate prefer the framing of the language as dormant rather than extinct: "A language is only dead if people do not speak it," Tahlate has stated. "It is simply sleeping in spaces where it was once spoken widely." The community continues to work from Johnson's documentation — recordings, transcriptions, and the linguistic work accumulated over his final decades — toward revitalization. The factual correction to this document: earlier source versions stated the Caddo language "is maintained." The living transmission chain has ended, but the revival work continues.

In August 2022, the Caddo Nation launched the Caddo Language Preservation Program, hiring Alaina Tahlate as the tribe's first dedicated language revitalizationist. This program — using the documentation accumulated during the final years of Edmond Johnson's life, including the 140+ hours of linguistic recordings he contributed — represents the primary vehicle for any future Caddo language revitalization. The loss of the last native speaker gives this work extraordinary urgency.

The Caddo and the Texas Word — Naming as Sacred Act

The word 'tayshas' — the Caddo word for 'friends' or 'allies' — has become the most enduring record of the Caddo people's presence in their homeland. When Spanish explorers arrived in Caddo territory in the late 17th century, the Hasinai communities they encountered extended their traditional greeting. The Spanish recorded 'Tejas,' and the word became the name of the region, the republic, and the state.

This is not merely linguistic history. The Caddo practice of extending welcome — 'friends, allies' — to strangers was a specific sacred practice grounded in the understanding that hospitality is a sacred obligation, that the stranger deserves the same welcome as the known community member because the sacred web of life includes all beings. The word 'Texas' is the record of a sacred greeting, preserved in the state's name even as the people who first spoke it were removed from the land.

Caddo Contact with Spanish and French Colonizers

The Caddo's first sustained European contact came in the late 17th century — the Spanish from Mexico pushing north through Texas, the French pushing west from Louisiana. The Caddo occupied the territory between these two colonial powers, and their diplomatic skill in playing them against each other preserved Caddo autonomy for nearly a century after first sustained contact.

The Spanish established missions in East Texas beginning in 1690, attempting to convert the Hasinai Caddo to Christianity. The missions were largely unsuccessful — the Caddo maintained their sacred tradition while diplomatically tolerating the Spanish presence as long as it served their interests. When the missions became more burdensome than beneficial, the Caddo exercised their diplomatic options to limit or expel them.

The French alliance was more productive for the Caddo — French Louisiana offered trade goods the Caddo valued (metal tools, firearms) without the Spanish insistence on religious conversion. The Caddo Nation at Natchitoches was the primary node of the French-Caddo alliance, and the French presence in Louisiana gave the Caddo a powerful counterbalance to Spanish pressure from the west.

The Removal — The Trail of Tears Comes to Texas

The Caddo's removal from their East Texas homeland was accomplished in stages across the 19th century. After Texas became an independent republic (1836) and then a US state (1845), pressure on Caddo lands intensified rapidly. The Republic of Texas, unlike the Spanish and French colonial powers before it, had no interest in the Caddo as trade partners or diplomatic allies — it wanted their land.

In 1854, the State of Texas established two reservations on the upper Brazos River for various Texas Indian nations, including the Caddo. These reservations provided temporary security but not permanence. By 1859, increasing violence from Anglo-Texan settlers who resented any Indian presence in Texas forced a crisis, and the federal government removed the Brazos Reserve Indians — including the Caddo — to Indian Territory (present-day Oklahoma) in a forced march that killed many of the most vulnerable participants.

The Caddo have never returned to their East Texas homeland as a political presence, though the Caddo Nation of Oklahoma maintains a living relationship with the Caddo Mounds and other sacred sites in Texas. The removal is the defining historical trauma of the contemporary Caddo experience, and the mounds' survival and their accessibility to the public represents a form of the Caddo presence persisting in the landscape even after the removal.

Contemporary Caddo — Language, Pottery, and Survival

The Caddo Nation of Oklahoma — headquartered in Binger, Oklahoma — is the federally recognized successor nation to the historic Caddo Confederacy. The nation has approximately 6,000 enrolled citizens, of whom a significant number live in southwestern Oklahoma near the tribal headquarters.

LANGUAGE PRESERVATION PROGRAM: In August 2022, the Caddo Nation launched a formal Language Preservation Program, hiring Alaina Tahlate as the tribe's first dedicated language revitalizationist. The program draws on the extensive documentation produced during Edmond Johnson's lifetime — audio recordings, transcribed texts, and the grammatical analysis produced through collaborative linguistic work — to develop learning materials, immersion experiences, and community education programs. The extinction of the last native speaker in July 2025 made this work both more urgent and more complicated: the program must now work from documentation rather than from living transmission.

POTTERY REVIVAL: The Caddo pottery revival — led by contemporary potters working to recover both the technical skills and the sacred design vocabulary of the tradition — represents one of the most successful cultural revitalization efforts in contemporary Caddo life. Contemporary Caddo potters are producing work that is exhibited in galleries and museums and that is worn and used by community members as expressions of living cultural identity.

THE MOUNDS: The Caddo Nation's relationship with the Caddo Mounds State Historic Site — particularly following the site's 2024 reopening after the 2019 tornado — represents the most visible contemporary expression of the Caddo's living relationship with their East Texas homeland. On November 15, 2025, the annual Caddo Culture Day returned to the site, featuring traditional Caddo cooking with Chase Kahwinhut Earles, stickball exhibitions, crafts, and storytelling — demonstrating the living connection between the ancient mounds and the contemporary Caddo Nation. The Caddo Nation participates in the site's interpretive programming and maintains a ceremonial relationship with the sacred landscape the mounds represent.

Caddo Sacred Wellness -- Kadohadacho and the Medicine Tradition

Caddo sacred wellness is organized around the understanding that the person exists within a web of sacred relationships -- with the Creator (Ayo-Kaddi, "the Father Above"), with the sacred beings of the celestial and natural world, with the community, and with the ancestors. Health in any dimension depends on right relationship in all dimensions. Illness is understood as a sign of disrupted relationship rather than a random biological event.

The caddis (Caddo medicine practitioners -- the term from which the Caddo people's own name may derive, meaning "real chiefs" or "true leaders") carried the specific healing knowledge of the tradition. The caddis conducted ceremony for healing, served as intermediaries between the human community and the sacred world, interpreted dreams and visions, and maintained the specific sacred knowledge encoded in the oral tradition. The caddis tradition required specific calling (often through illness or vision in youth) and specific apprenticeship under established practitioners.

The Caddo sacred fire -- the perpetually maintained fire at the center of the caddi's house, from which all household fires in the community were lit -- was simultaneously a cosmological center, a political institution, and a wellness technology. The specific protocols around the sacred fire (what may and may not be done near it, who may tend it, what offerings are appropriate) maintained the community in a specific state of ceremonial attention that the tradition held as the foundation of collective health. When the fire was properly maintained and the appropriate ceremonies were conducted, the community was protected and sustained.

Plant medicine: The Caddo homeland -- stretching across the Red River valley and the Piney Woods of East Texas and western Louisiana -- is one of the most botanically diverse landscapes in North America, and the Caddo medicine tradition drew on this richness extensively. Specific plants for specific conditions, gathered in specific seasons with specific prayers, formed the material basis of the caddis's healing practice. The 2022 Caddo Language Preservation Program has focused particular attention on preserving the Caddo names for medicinal plants alongside their uses -- recognizing that the therapeutic knowledge and the linguistic knowledge are inseparable.

The Haligrity Lens — Sacred Hospitality and the Original Texas Welcome

The Caddo tradition offers Haligrity several gifts of specific philosophical and practical relevance — but the one that speaks most directly from the heart of the tradition is the simplest: the word 'tayshas,' extended as a greeting to strangers, became the name of the largest state in the contiguous United States.

The Caddo extended hospitality — 'friends, allies' — to the Spanish explorers who arrived in their territory at the end of the 17th century. This welcome was not naive; it was a specific sacred practice, grounded in the understanding that the stranger deserves the same welcome as the known community member because the sacred web of life includes all beings, not just the familiar ones. The word that became 'Texas' is the record of that sacred welcome — preserved in the state's name even as the people who first spoke it were removed from the land.

"Tayshas — friends, allies. The word the Caddo spoke became the name of the land. The greeting outlasted the removal."

— On the Caddo origin of the word Texas

The Caddo Mounds State Historic Site is near Alto, Texas — in the East Texas Piney Woods that the Caddo have called home for at least a thousand years. The contemporary Caddo Nation of Oklahoma maintains a living relationship with the mounds, the language documentation, and the ceremonies. The pottery tradition is being revived. The Morning Star still rises over East Texas every spring. The Black Drink still purifies those who approach with sincerity. The people whose word named the state are still here. Grand Rising.